organization. Greens were earthy people who cared deeply about personal relationships. Swanny was an obvious yellow, brash and insistent.

In current terms, Ben Stokes is a classic red, fiery and emotional, but personality colours can bleed between boundaries. We learned over time to accept Andy Flower as a blend of blue and red. His attention to detail underpinned his coaching style, but he responded aggressively if he felt standards were slipping.

He made a pivotal intervention in that Ashes series, after we surrendered the initiative, and the series lead, in the fourth Test at Headingley. We failed to live up to our promises to ourselves. It was an ugly defeat, by an innings and eighty runs, that threatened to undo all our previous application and adventure.

The tone of our work had been set in the initial Test at Cardiff. Once Colly's admirable resistance, in scoring 74 runs with soft hands and hard-headed defiance, had been broken, Jimmy and Monty Panesar batted memorably for sixty-nine excruciatingly tense deliveries to save the day. That unbroken last-wicket stand was like a buddy movie – part comedy, part drama.

We built upon that reprieve in the second Test, our first Ashes victory at Lord's since 1934. I was trapped leg before by Mitchell Johnson for 95 after an opening stand of 196 with Straussy. His monumental 161, combined with Freddie's five-wicket farewell to HQ as an international cricketer in Australia's second innings, set up a 115-run win that augured well.

The loss at Headingley represented everything we wished to exclude from our game. We were sloppy and submissive. We didn't have an immediate 'naughty boys' meeting' in the dressing room, but Flower had his say later, back at the hotel, before he threw the floor open. As in the Caribbean, he enabled us to speak openly, honestly and harshly. It cleared the air and renewed our focus. We admitted to the collective mistake of envisaging the outcome, winning the Ashes, instead of focusing on the process. It didn't go unnoticed that outsiders couldn't wait to write us off.

I didn't mind the occasional bite and bark. I never regarded Andy as particularly fierce, because I had the advantage of having played with him at Essex. I saw the softer, more collaborative aspect of his nature as a youngster coming through, but had also witnessed the fiery side of a man who could snap and have an argument.